

How To Fix Toxic Work Culture

with **Colin D Ellis** · author of Detox Your Culture

Toxic culture is rarely a surprise. Ignoring bad behaviour is permitting it.

Culture is never accidental. It is created, shaped and reinforced daily by what leaders choose to allow, encourage and act on. Toxic cultures emerge gradually when poor behaviour goes unaddressed and people look the other way. Understand what drives culture, connect it to strategy, and spot the early warning signs, and you can build an environment where people and performance thrive.

TOP 3 TAKEAWAYS

01

Two drivers of a thriving culture

Map **emotional intelligence** against **engagement** on a 2x2 and team cultures explain themselves. Both high: vibrant and thriving. It shows why some teams felt positive and productive, and why others struggled, and gives you a clearer path to building great environments.

02

Toxic cultures escalate in three stages

- **Combative** · high pressure, bad behaviour tolerated
- **Corrosive** · harmful behaviour rewarded
- **Harmful** · serious impact on wellbeing and safety

Confronting, but a reminder of why early action matters.

03

Culture and strategy are partners

Culture, vision, values and strategy are all connected and equally important. To deliver a strategy, be deliberate about building the culture that carries it.

"Build a great culture, and your people will write you a great strategy."

PUT IT TO WORK



Think

Pick one thing to do this week: raise emotional intelligence (active listening) or lift engagement (involve others in a decision).



Read

Colin's new book, [Detox Your Culture](#), goes deeper on spotting and fixing the three stages.



Act

Name one tolerated-but-uncomfortable behaviour in your team and take a small step: start the conversation, give the feedback, or inform a leader. And next time you work on strategy, pause and ask: **"What culture do we need to bring this to life?"**

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My next steps



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